

British physicist and chemist Michael Faraday was one of the most influential scientists of the 19th century. His multiple, unprecedented contributions to the fields of electricity and electromagnetism paved the way for an electrical revolution that would change the modern world.

Michael Faraday was born in a poor area of south London, and at age 13 was apprenticed to a bookbinder. As well as learning the art of bookbinding, he read avidly, particularly scientific texts, and developed a thirst for scientific endeavor. After attending a lecture by British chemist Humphry Davy in 1812, Faraday wrote up his copious lecture notes, bound them, and sent them to Davy. Davy offered him a job as his assistant at the Royal Institution (RI) the following year, which set Faraday on a course of scientific inquiry that would revolutionize the world.

At the Royal Institution

Early in his time at the Royal Institution, Faraday accompanied Davy on a tour of Europe, during which he met many high-profile scientists and greatly furthered his scientific education and curiosity. Despite his lack of formal education, Faraday swiftly progressed from assisting Davy to conducting his own experiments. Under Davy's mentorship, he wrote a chemistry manual, discovered new organic compounds (notably

“One of the greatest scientific discoverers **of all time.**”

Ernest Rutherford, 1931

MILESTONES

ROYAL INSTITUTION

Accepts a job with Davy in 1813 at the Royal Institution. Becomes professor of chemistry in 1833.

KEY DISCOVERIES

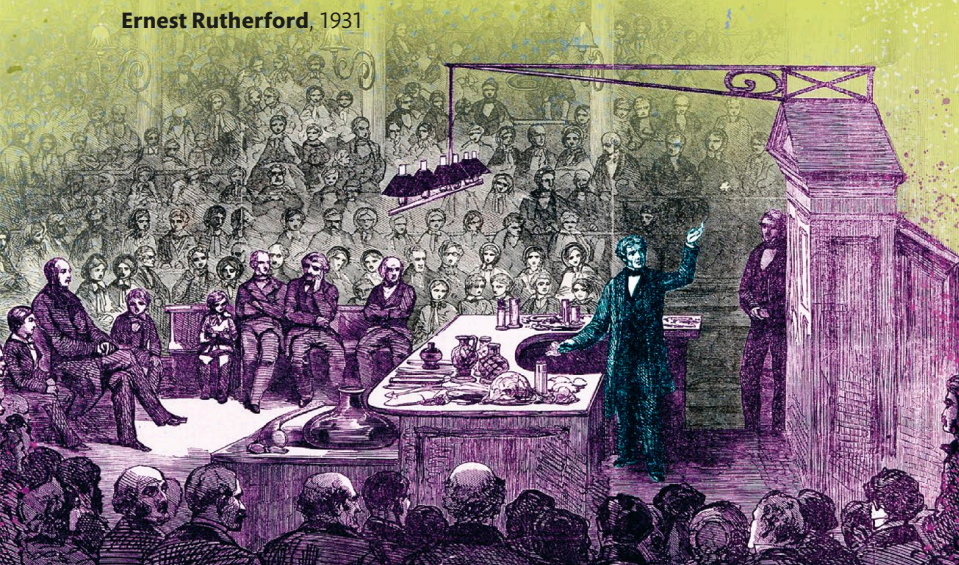
Invents the world's first electric motor in 1821 and discovers how to generate electricity 10 years later.

CHEMICAL WORK

Discovers benzene in 1825; in 1834, publishes laws of electrolysis (electrically splitting chemicals).

LIGHT CONNECTION

In 1845, demonstrates for the first time the revelatory link between light and magnetism.



Faraday carried out his research in conjunction with giving regular lectures at the Royal Institution for wide audiences. He hosted 19 public lectures, which were frequently attended by members of the Royal Family.